

Artists' colors

PAINTING THE TOWN RED, BLUE, YELLOW, GREEN ...

IN THE SOUTHEASTERN CORNER OF BUENOS AIRES, near the waterfront, lies the historic working-class *barrio*, or neighborhood, of La Boca; *boca* means mouth, and the district was named for the mouth of the Riachuelo River, which winds along its southern border. Full of ancient cobbled streets and rickety houses made of wood and tin, La Boca grew up as the city's Italian quarter during its first flush of prosperity at the end of the 19th century. Soon, the immigrant families who lived here began to adopt an appealing custom from the port of Genoa, where people brightened their streets with paint left over from the building and refitting of ships in the harbor. Today, the streets of La Boca are inhabited by a lively colony of artists and bohemians who take great delight in carrying on this tradition—every corrugated sheet, plank of wood, wrought-iron balustrade, and fretwork panel sings out in dazzling crimson, cobalt, aqua, or saffron.

